

5 Key Principles of Climbing Training

Charlie Schreiber, CSCS

This eBook helps climbers train with intention, not guesswork—offering high-impact concepts you can apply immediately while sharpening how you think so every rep, rest, and decision on the wall matters more.

Coach Charlie Schreiber, CSCS, is the founder of Paradigm Climbing and a professional climbing coach with 19 years of climbing experience, a background in competitive climbing up to the World Cup level, route setting, climbing up to the V13 and 5.14a level and long-term athlete development. Over his 16 years of coaching, Charlie has personally trained over 1000 climbers and has mentored multiple athletes to progress from Day 1, V0 to the V16 and V17 level. His work focuses on helping climbers understand why and how training works—not just what to do—so they can move beyond unstructured training and take ownership of their progress.

The Green Day Philosophy

Why Training that Feels "Easy" Often Works Better

Climbers love to train hard. We chase that feeling of pump, maximal sending, and the feeling that we did enough. But here's the uncomfortable truth:

Getting tired is easy. Creating meaningful adaptations is harder.

That gap between effort and adaptation is where most climbers lose years of progress. It's also where the Green Day philosophy comes into play.

What is a Green Day?

A Green Day is a session where you:

- Arrive feeling fully or mostly recovered
- Hit your training goals with high-quality effort
- Leave feeling like your body has adapted, not exhausted its resources

The catch? You don't know it was truly a Green Day until your next session feels better: stronger, sharper, and more coordinated.
That's the metric. Not soreness. Not exhaustion. Not how wrecked you feel walking out of the gym. And while it may feel difficult to recognize this at first, as you observe how your sessions stack up on one another over time, it becomes easier to recognize when to call it quits.

The Color Spectrum of Training Outcomes

Every session lands somewhere on this spectrum:

- *Green Day: You improve*
- *Yellow Day: You maintain*
- *Orange Day: You train too fatigued, gains are slightly negative*
- *Red Day: You dig a recovery hole*
- *Black Day: Biggest injury potential – you're hit with a hard time-out*

Most climbers think improvement comes from pushing into orange and red territory, at least subconsciously. In reality, progress comes from stacking green days over weeks and months. It's not a flashy training philosophy, but it's incredibly effective.

Why Green Days Prevent Plateaus and Injuries

Overuse injuries and stalled progress don't usually come from one bad decision, they come from too many non-Green Days in a row.
When intensity and volume stay high while recovery lags behind:

- Tendons accumulate fatigue
- Strength and power decline
- Mental sharpness erodes
- Injury risk skyrockets

Green Day training flips the goal: You're no longer trying to see how much you can handle today, you're trying to make sure every session is better.
That shift alone changes everything.

Load Management, Simplified

Instead of obsessing over perfect RPE scores or spreadsheets, Green Days focus on internal response:

- How does this session feel relative to my expectations?
- Am I hitting goals with control, or just barely hanging on?
- Does my body feel more capable afterward—or less?

You still vary volume and intensity. You still cycle focus (strength, endurance, technique). But decisions are guided by your body's readiness, not ego.
Rest days, sleep, nutrition, hydration—these aren't "extras." They're what turn today's effort into tomorrow's Green Day.

How to Apply Green Days This Week

A Simple Green Day Filter

Ask yourself these questions – and write them down – each training day. Over time, you'll start to recognize your patterns, and eventually be able to recognize your green days with ease.

Before the session:

- Do I feel recovered enough to train with intent?
- What is one clear goal today?

During the session:

- Am I moving well, or just muscling through?
- If this feels 1–2 levels harder than expected, how can I adjust?
- Am I experiencing any early warning signs?

End the session when:

- Quality drops
- Grip or coordination noticeably fades
- You think, "One more hard try…"
- That's usually the line.

Sample Green Day Session (Strength Focus)

- Warm up thoroughly
- 2–4 high-quality limit boulders, 3-5 tries each
- Long rests, HIGH effort
- Stopping while you still feel sharp

If your next session feels better—not worse—you nailed it.

You don't train to get tired. You train to adapt. When you start protecting Green Days and letting go of the need to "empty the tank," progress stops feeling fleeting. It becomes repeatable. Sustainable. Reliable. That's how strong climbers are built.



Load Management

WHAT IS LOAD?

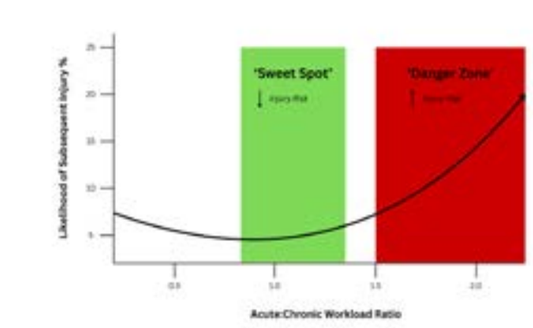
In climbing, every move you make applies load to your body. Every grab, pull, lock-off and session overall adds stress to your muscles, tendons, joints, and nervous system. Whether you adapt and get stronger—or stall, burn out, or get injured—depends on how that load is managed.

So what is load? At its simplest, **Load = Volume × Intensity.** But in practice, load is more nuanced than "how hard you trained."
Understanding load is one of the most important skills a climber can develop. It's the difference between training hard for years and training well for decades.

Acute vs. Chronic Load

Acute load is the stress from a single session or short time window. A long projecting day, repeated limit boulder attempts, or a heavy hangboard workout all create acute load.

Chronic load is the accumulation of those sessions over weeks and months. This is the load your body is actually adapting to. Progress happens when chronic load increases gradually. Injuries happen when acute load spikes faster than your body can tolerate.



The "U" relationship between ACWR & injury risk (%). Source: Science for Sport

Sports science describes this balance using the **Acute:Chronic Workload Ratio (ACWR)**. When recent training exceeds what your body has been prepared for, injury risk rises sharply. Too little load, and you decondition. Too much, too fast, and injury has a MUCH higher potential to occur.

The ACWR compares how much training you've done in the last 7 days (acute load) to what your body has done over the last 3–4 weeks (chronic load), giving you a snapshot of whether you're progressing safely or spiking too fast. To calculate your ratio, assign each of your sessions a load score as you train (**session duration × RPE)**, sum the last 7 days for acute load, average the last 21–28 days for chronic load, then divide **acute ÷ chronic**.

Most climbers don't get injured because they're weak, but because they change their training faster than their body can adapt. The sweet spot for ACWR sits between **0.8 and 1.3**. Stay there, and you're applying enough stress to improve while giving your tissues time to adapt. Push above **1.5**, and you've likely created a spike. Think adding extra board sessions, doubling project days, or stacking hard workouts because motivation is high. On paper it looks productive; in your body it shows up as finger tweakiness, feeling heavy, and sloppy movement. Conversely, if you drop below **0.8**, the opposite happens: you detrain just enough that your progression plateaus.

The insight most climbers miss is this: you don't need to fully shut things down when you overshoot intensity. A short "step-down" phase works better: reduce volume and intensity by 30–50% for a few days, keep moving, sleep more, and let your chronic load catch up. From there, rebuild gradually, increasing total load by no more than 10–15% per week. When you plan training this way—ramping up during focused blocks and intentionally backing off during deloads—you stop riding the boom-and-bust cycle. You train hard, stay healthy, and actually stack progress instead of restarting every few months.

The takeaway is simple but highly effective:
You don't need to train harder; you need to avoid sudden spikes in intensity.

Smart climbers build load progressively, use deloads intentionally, and understand that rest isn't lost time—it's where adaptation happens.

Volume vs. Intensity

Volume and intensity are the two levers that determine load.

- Volume is how much work you do: total climbs, moves, attempts, or time on the wall.
- Intensity is how hard the work is: how close you are to your physical limit.

Many climbers fall into the trap of chasing volume – doing lots of climbs that feel productive, but never truly challenge their limits. Others do the opposite: stacking too many max-effort sessions without enough recovery.

Both approaches stall progress. There's no balance. Strength and power require high intensity with controlled volume. Endurance and capacity require higher volume at lower intensity. Trying to max both at once usually leads to fatigue, sloppy movement, and plateaus. Progress comes from knowing when to emphasize each, and cycling them over time.

External vs. Internal Load

External load is measurable: grades climbed, attempts made, time on the wall, added weight.
Internal load is how your body responds: perceived effort, fatigue, coordination, motivation, and recovery.

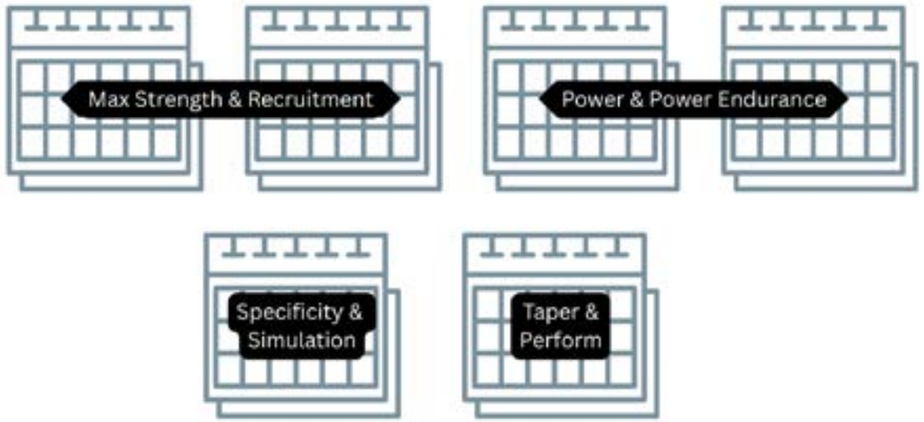
Two sessions can look identical on paper but produce wildly different internal responses. Ignoring internal load is how climbers drift into overtraining, still "hitting the numbers," but feeling worse each week.

Learning to monitor internal signals such as energy, focus, soreness, and mood is a skill. And it's one of the most reliable ways to train hard without breaking down. It's critical to adapt your training sessions to how you actually feel each day, rather than blindly trying to stick to your training plan.

The Big Idea

Load isn't about doing more, it's about applying the right stress, in the right amount, at the right time, then allowing recovery so your body can adapt. Understanding load empowers you to stop guessing. Sessions gain purpose. Rest gains value. Progress becomes repeatable.

In the full book, this concept expands into weekly planning, long-term cycles, deload strategies, and how to stack "good days" so progress compounds instead of collapses.



Periodizing Your Training: An sample training calendar with periodized training over the course of 6 months.

How to Periodize Properly

Most climbers don't fail because they're lazy. They fail because they train everything at once. Strength, power, endurance, technique, volume, mileage—stacked together in the same week, sometimes the same session. The result? You're busy, fatigued, and your training plateaus.

Periodization solves this. It's not academic. It's not elite-only. It's simply the art of organizing your training so energy systems build on each other instead of competing.

At its core, periodization means this:
Develop one primary adaptation at a time—then layer the next on top.
You don't sharpen a blade before forging the steel. Climbing is no different.

The Big Idea: Don't Peak for Your Training

The goal of training isn't to feel strong every training session. The goal is to perform when it matters—when the project is in season, or you're heading to an important competition.
Periodization gives you a roadmap to get there. Instead of throwing random stimulus at your body, you intentionally move through phases:

1. *Build capacity*
2. *Convert it to usable power*
3. *Apply it to real climbing*
4. *Back off and perform*

Now let's see what this might actually look like.

A Real-World Example: Peaking for Joe's Valley

You're planning a Joe's Valley trip in October. It's May now—about five months out. Here's how a boulderer might periodize that window.

Phase 1: Max Strength & Recruitment (May–June)

Goal: Build peak force production and sharpen motor-unit recruitment

- 7 - 12 second hangs hangs/lifts
- 80-95% 1RM Weighted pull-ups
- 3-6 move limit boulders
- Low reps, long rest, high intent

Key rule: Keep volume low enough that every rep is explosive and precise. If we don't start by building the foundation, training the other energy systems feels a lot harder.

Phase 2: Power & Power Endurance (July–August)

Goal: Turn strength into movement.
Now you teach your body to use that strength repeatedly.

- Longer boulders (6–12 moves)
- Boulder linkups
- Dynamic coordination and contact strength
- Repeat efforts with quality maintained

One max-strength session per week stays in to maintain your gains. This is where rhythm, snap, and flow begin to emerge.

Phase 3: Specificity & Simulation (September)

Goal: Translate raw strength into send-ready flow.
Strength only matters if it transfers. This phase is about matching the demands of your project zone.

- Performing under mild fatigue
- Big spans and body tension
- Redpoint-style attempts or simulations of your project
- High-quality outdoor sessions

You're no longer chasing adaptations—you're practicing performance.

Phase 4: Taper & Perform (October)

Goal: Show up fresh and dangerous.
Training volume drops. Outdoor quality rises.

- Fewer sessions, more rest
- Visualization and highly intentional attempts
- Skin and recovery become priorities

You trust the work and let your body express it.

How to Apply This to Your Training

Start with one question:
When do I want to perform my best?
Then work backward.

Sample Weekly Prompt

- What is my primary focus this phase?
- Which sessions directly support that adaptation?
- What can I remove to improve workout efficacy and recovery?

If your main goal is max strength, power work becomes background noise. If power is the goal, marathon-length sessions disappear.

Periodization isn't complicated—it's intentional. One shouldn't try to be ready to perform all the time. Be ready when it counts. When temps drop and friction improves, you want to make sure your training lines up.

How to Structure a Training Week

Build Momentum, Don't Burn Out

A good training week doesn't happen by accident. It's designed. While training too much volume without precise focus can lead to burnout and fatigue, following an intentional and structured training plan creates **momentum**. Momentum in your training comes from small wins stacking on top of each other, creating a feedback loop that keeps you coming back for more.

Momentum builds from clarity, rhythm, and repeatable wins.

Every climber has their ideal training cadence. For some, it's three intense sessions per week. For others, it's a rhythm of light-skill, heavy-load, active recovery, and repeat. The goal is to find a tempo that lets you stay in the game and make progress without overloading your system.

Core Principle: Rhythm Over Chaos

Your body adapts best when stress follows a pattern. Hard days need space for recovery. Skill work needs freshness. Recovery needs intention. When your week has a rhythm, you stop guessing—and consistency becomes automatic.

Think of your training week as a **microcycle**: a small loop of stress, adaptation, and reset that repeats again and again. Each day has a job. Each session earns its place. Consistency with your climbing, workouts, and rest days is key to success.

Hard Days vs. Skill Days

One of the most important shifts you can make is separating training days from skill-focused days. This can help you keep your training balanced.

Training Days

These target physical adaptations. They're demanding and require recovery.

- Max strength workouts (fingerboard, weighted pulls, etc)
- Limit bouldering
- Power or power-endurance intervals

These sessions are few throughout the week, but high quality.



Photo by Dylan Hickerson.

Example Weekly Microcycle

M Strength Session (Limit bouldering, max strength exercises)	T Aerobic Base Building (Arcing, low-level circuits)	W Rest Day/Optional Mobility Day	T Power Endurance (4x4s, moderate circuits with limited rest)
F Rest Day	S Strength Session	S Rest Day/Optional Mobility Day	

Structuring with Micro Cycles: Treating each week as a microcycle can help you ensure that every training day is designed to work towards your big-picture goals.

Momentum Is Built From Small Wins

Structure your week to include achievable progress markers:

- One extra second on a hang
- One new link on your gym project
- One session where movement feels easier

These micro-wins compound. They keep motivation high and effort consistent Progress doesn't come from heroic, all-out sessions. It comes from weeks you can repeat and stacking small gains over time.

Build Flexibility Into the Plan

Life will disrupt your schedule. That's not failure, it's reality. The easier it is for you to adapt to life's unexpected changes, the more successful your training plan will be.

Decide ahead of time:

- Which weekly session is optional?
- Which session is non-negotiable?
- What does a "low-energy version" of this week look like?

Climbers who progress long-term aren't rigid. They adapt without quitting.

A good training week is **intentional, repeatable, and aligned with both your climbing goals and your life.** When your structure matches your capacity, effort stops feeling forced, and progress starts stacking quietly in the background.

Progress is built just like that, one week at a time.

Scan to watch more of our content on structuring your training.

Why Most Climbers Plateau

Climbers plateau when training stops being intentional and starts being reactive: chasing sends, pushing through fatigue, copying flashy Instagram workouts, or mistaking “doing more” for “doing better.” The common thread? Ignoring the signals that tell you when training has stopped working.

It comes from **misdirected effort**, not a lack of effort. It happens when drills and workouts are repeated just long enough to feel productive—but not long enough to create adaptation. Or, when too many drills are repeated together, and there’s no cohesion.
Let’s break down the biggest reasons climbers get stuck—and how to step off the plateau before it hardens into your new normal.

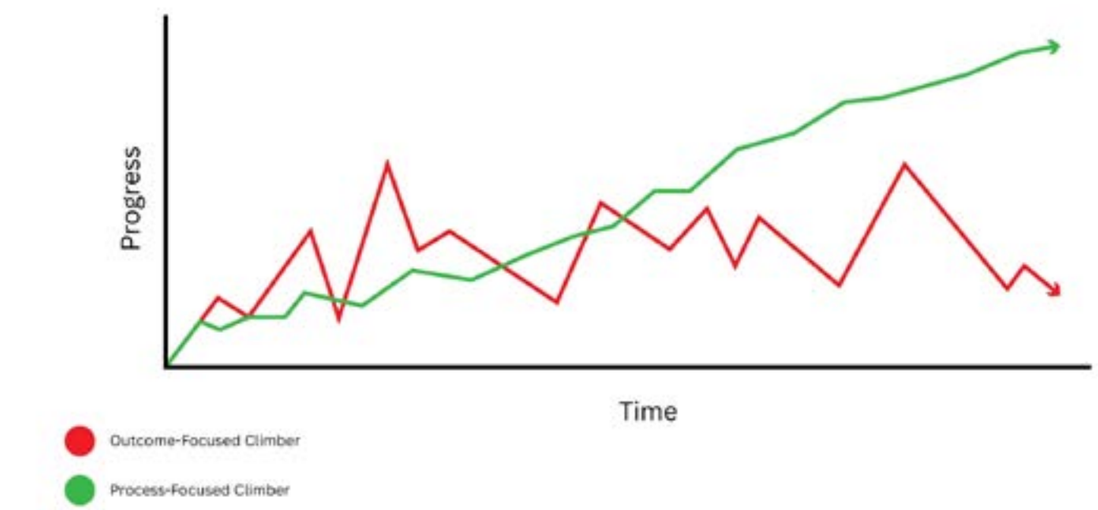
#1: Ignoring the Early Warning Signs

Plateaus often begin in the body, not the grade chart.

- Nagging pain in fingers, elbows, and shoulders (or any joints)
- Loss of power, where your typical snapiness is gone
- Fatigue that lingers longer than usual

These aren’t just annoyances—they’re signs that your recovery isn’t keeping up with training stress. When tendons and nervous system fatigue accumulate, your body shifts from adapting to surviving. Progress stalls, even though effort stays high.

Key takeaway: Pain and persistent fatigue don’t mean you need more grit. They mean you need smarter load management.



Outcome vs Process: Focusing on the enjoying the process rather than the outcome, is essential to sustainable training progress.

#2: Your Technique and Focus Subtly Degrade

When climbers plateau, form is often the first thing to slip. Hips drift away from the wall. Feet slap around instead of placing precisely. Movement feels forced instead of fluid. Mentally, focus frays: sequencing is rushed, visualization disappears, and frustration creeps in.

At this point, every extra attempt reinforces sloppier movement patterns, rather than intentional ones. You’re practicing bad habits, which will reflect negatively on your climbing in the long run.

Rule of thumb: When technique and focus decline noticeably, the session has already passed its productive window.

#3: Psyche Overrules Physiology

Climbers are famously a highly motivated group, which is both a powerful strength and a great limitation.

You feel psyched, so you keep going. But output drops, warm-ups take longer, and peak strength fades faster. The mind says yes; but all these signs point towards the body saying no.

This disconnect is one of the fastest ways to plateau. Training only works when stress lands inside the body’s window of ability to adapt. Push past that window too often, and you don’t build strength, you accumulate fatigue.
Many of my biggest breakthroughs came during cycles where I wrote one rule at the top of my training log:

“Stop the session while it still feels good.”

Those cycles produced progress. The others produced fatigue.

#4: Training Without Clear Endpoints

One of the most common plateau drivers is the phrase “just one more try.”

Without a predefined end point, whether it’s a time limit, attempt cap, or quality threshold, sessions creep into junk volume. Intensity drops, frustration rises, and recovery debt piles up.

Climbers who progress long-term decide before the session:

- What success looks like
- What signals the end of the session

Discipline here isn’t restrictive—it’s freeing, and it allows you to gain exponentially more from your training.

Most climbers don’t plateau because they’re weak, but because they don’t know when to stop or what to prioritize. Progress lives in that narrow space where effort, recovery, and intention overlap. Learn to recognize it, protect it, and return to it consistently, and plateaus stop being permanent.

Overlap

There's a moment almost every motivated climber goes through: the training soup session. Max hangs. Campus board. 4x4s. Core finisher. Two hours later, you're wrecked beyond return and convinced you just leveled up.

I've been there. And instead of getting stronger, I just got sore, tired, and felt worse at everything.
The lesson took years to sink in, but it's simple and foundational:
Training hard isn't the same as training effectively.
If you want consistent gains and fewer plateaus, you have to avoid **overlap**.

The Problem with Doing Everything at Once

Your body isn't great at multitasking Neurologically, it prefers one clear message at a time.



Photo by Dylan Hickerson.

Each training method sends a signal:

- Max hangs = peak force and neural recruitment
- Campus board = explosive power and contact strength
- Circuits = fatigue tolerance and energy system stress
- Volume climbing = efficiency and movement economy

When you stack incompatible signals into one session, you don't get the benefits of all of them—you dilute them.

For example: If you start a session with heavy max hangs (low reps, high intensity, full rest), you're telling your nervous system to fire hard and precisely. But if you immediately follow that with pumpy endurance circuits, you teach the opposite lesson: produce force while tired. The original adaptation gets blurred.

It's the climbing equivalent of trying to train sprint speed by running a marathon right after your 40-yard dash. You don't become faster, you just get tired.

One Dominant Stimulus Per Session

High-level athletes follow a deceptively simple rule:

One primary adaptation per session.

That doesn't mean your session has to be boring or robotic. It means everything you do should support one goal, not compete with it. Warm-ups prepare the nervous system. Accessory work reinforces stability or resilience. But the session has a clear centerpiece.

Before every workout, ask:

What adaptation am I trying to move forward today?

If you can't answer that clearly, the session is probably doing too much, and accomplishing too little.

Progress One Quality at a Time

It's tempting to want everything at once: stronger fingers, better power, more endurance, cleaner movement. The problem? Adaptation needs consistency and time. If you bounce between goals week to week, your body never settles into a groove long enough to change.

Focused blocks of training wins every time – see Chapter 6 on periodization for more in-depth information on how to structure your training into these blocks. Holding off on some training goals doesn't mean you're ignoring weaknesses—you're just waiting for the right time to train them.

Progress isn't simultaneous. It's cumulative.

Example: Strength-Focused Session (Minimal Overlap)

Goal: Improve max finger strength
Duration: ~90 minutes

- Progressive warm-up (easy movement, gradual loading)
- Limit bouldering session - 3-5 attempts each, rest at least 1 minute per move executed. 4-6 move boulders at an RPE of 8-10:
  - *1 crimp boulder*
  - *1 pinch boulder*
  - *1 sloper boulder (optional)*
  - *1 pocket boulder (optional)*
- Light antagonist or shoulder stability work
- Stop climbing while performance is still high

No circuits. No pump. No fatigue chasing. Having that restraint is what allows adaptation to happen. You can't push your maximum strength threshold when you're fatigued, so focus your efforts in a way that maximizes their efficacy.

Overlap in Grip

Finally, this same principle of avoiding overlap applies directly to grip selection. Even when sessions are well-structured, injury risk skyrockets if too many high-stress grip angles overlap across days or weeks. The fingers don't experience "variety" the way the brain does—tissues experience load at specific joint angles.

If you're consistently training high-angle half crimp, closed crimp, or aggressive drag positions, you may be repeatedly stressing the same vulnerable structures—most commonly the middle finger PIP joint, the middle knuckle region, the A2 pulley of the ring finger, and the flexor digitorum profundus (FDP).

To build a resilient and well-rounded strength portfolio, you should intentionally rotate grip angles and loading patterns over time. That means balancing high-angle grips with lower-angle half crimps, open hand positions, slopers, pinches, and varied wrist orientations.

Overlap in grip stress doesn't just limit adaptation—it quietly accumulates tissue fatigue until it shows up as pain. Smart climbers don't just ask how hard they're loading their fingers—they ask where that load is landing, and whether the same structures are being taxed again and again without relief.



Photo by Dylan Hickerson.

Climbing Identity & Psychology

Climbing has always been a mental sport. Strength matters. Technique matters. But when attempts blur together, fear creeps in, or pressure hijacks your movement, it's mindset, not muscle, that determines the outcome.

Mindset isn't about blind positivity. It's the set of beliefs, habits, and mental skills that shape how you respond to challenge. And like finger strength or footwork, it's trainable.

Fixed vs. Growth: The Identity You Climb With

Every climber operates from an implicit belief about ability.

A fixed mindset treats performance as a verdict: I'm good at this or I'm not. Failure feels threatening, so weaknesses get avoided and falls feel personal.

A growth mindset treats performance as information. Ability is viewed as adaptable, shaped by effort, strategy, and time. Failure becomes feedback, not identity.

The shift starts with awareness. Notice the personal narratives that surface when things get hard:
"I'm terrible at slabs."
"I always choke on this style."
"I should be climbing X grade by now."
Observe these internal thought patters, then reframe the language:
"I haven't mastered this yet."
That single word keeps the nervous system curious instead of defensive, and curiosity is where learning happens.

Process Over Outcome: Where Real Progress Lives

In climbing, the process isn't the path to mastery—it is mastery. Outcome-focused climbers ride emotional rollercoasters: elated after a send, deflated after a fall. Process-focused climbers stay psychologically steady.

Each attempt becomes data: body position, breathing, pacing, commitment are all informed by your successes and failures throughout a session – but none of them reflect negatively on who you are as a climber.
This matters biologically. When attention is on execution rather than judgment:

- Stress hormones stabilize
- Motor learning accelerates
- Flow becomes more accessible

Success stops being "sending." Success becomes learning something useful every attempt.

Confidence Is Built, Not Declared

Confidence isn't mindless hype. It's evidence. In psychology, this is called **self-efficacy**—trust built through repeated experiences of effort leading to improvement. Each small win strengthens the internal belief: I can handle this.

Cockiness ignores feedback. Confidence collects it.

You build confidence by:

- Facing manageable challenge
- Executing with intention
- Reflecting on what worked
- Acknowledging progress (out loud or on paper)

Over time, this creates a stable internal signal: I've been here before. I know what to do.

Failure as Data, Not Drama

Falling is not the problem. The meaning you attach to it is. Resilient climbers treat failure as an experiment. Rather than beating yourself up when you fall, ask yourself these questions:

- *Technical: What broke down?/What came off the wall first?*
- *Physical: What fatigued first?*
- *Mental: Where did fear or hesitation show up, and how did that affect my execution?*

This reframing shifts the brain out of threat mode and back into problem-solving. Instead of reacting emotionally, you adapt strategically. That's resilience.

How to Apply This in Training (This Week)

Before the Session
Choose **1–2 process goals**, not outcomes:
"Breathe steadily through the crux"
"Commit fully to dynamic moves"
"Maintain shoulder engagement under fatigue"

Say them out loud or write them down. Then, keep yourself accountable during the session to stick to it.

During Attempts
After each go, ask:

- What changed?
- What felt better?
- What's one adjustment for next time?

Avoid "good/bad" labels. Be descriptive. Identify what actually needs to change in your climbing. Filming your attempts is a great way to identify what improvements need to be made.

After the Session (5 minutes)
In a journal, record the following:

- One thing that improved during the session
- One thing you learned
- One reason it matters

Writing it down locks progress into memory.

Mindset isn't separate from training—it is training, and it's just as important as the physical component. When you learn to manage focus, fear, and identity with the same intention you bring to strength and technique, climbing stops volatile.

Progress becomes repeatable. You become adaptable. And your mindset becomes far more powerful in the moments it matters most.